Judaism

Judaism is one of the oldest monotheistic religions, with more than 14 million followers worldwide. The religion stems from its founder, Abraham, who established a covenant with God and later set the foundation of the Jewish teachings, the Torah. Rabbis were spiritual leaders who oversaw the society, maintaining high positions across government and religious assemblies known as synagogues. From Egyptian enslavement to Babylonian exile and to the Holocaust, the Judaic community endured mistreatment. While Judaism faced a history of suffering and oppression, the Jewish community persevered by following the principles of the Torah. The Rabbis' leadership positions continued the tradition of monotheism throughout time, guiding the Jewish people despite their hardships.

Judaism first emerged with the revelation of God to a man named Abraham, revealing the promise of a holy land given to the community by God. During this covenance, Abraham was told that if his descendants worshiped God, they would be as numerous as the stars in the sky and inhabit the holy land of Canaan. This agreement between God and Abraham set the monotheistic principles in the Torah, where the land was "given" by God, and the people must follow righteous qualities and devote themselves to God.

Followers of Judaism faced suffering between the 5th and 7th centuries BCE. Of these many conflicts, the ones with the most significant impact were the Assyrian exile and the Babylonian Captivity. During these two major events, the Israelites were kicked out of their home. The first event, known as the Assyrian exile, occurred around the 7th century BCE. Before the exile, King Solomon ruled over the united nation of Israel, but after he passed away, Israel split into different tribes. The ten tribes located in the north were known as Israel and were

ruled by King Jeroboam, while the two tribes in the south came to be known as Judea, ruled by King Rehoboam, who was the son of King Solomon. From the 9th to the 7th century, 19 kings ruled the ten tribes. During this time, the citizens and followers of Judaism disobeyed the ideas of the prophets such as Elijah and Amos. After over two centuries of disobedience to god and his prophets, it was thought that the Jewish god sent the Emperor of Assyria to invade Israel and "removed [Israel] from His sight" by calling Assyria to invade the land and remove a large number of the people (Isaiah 5:26; 7:18).

Throughout time, the Rabbi emerged and helped weave important relationships between the people and the Jewish culture. They started flourishing around 70 CE after the destruction of the Second Temple during the Roman Empire (Neusner 278). By maintaining important positions in academia, government, and legislation, the Rabbi promoted the teachings of the Torah within their community. They also acted in spiritual customs, including weddings, processions, and funerals. In many Israeli states, the present government is run by two national chief Rabbis, the Ministry of Religion and the Chief Rabbinate. The rabbi aimed to create a system of worship centered around the Torah, and this was through the synagogues, where the community gathered together.

A fundamental belief brought by the Rabbi is the belief in reward and punishment. In the Torah, death is viewed as a transition to the afterlife. Upon death, the soul separates from the body and experiences varying states of existence, which may include suffering or reward based on one's actions during life. Resurrection is also seen as a future event in the Torah where individuals will be brought back to life. Sa'adiah proposes that resurrection is a temporary phenomenon, where the righteous are revived to live embodied lives before returning to a disembodied state in the world to come (Brody 98).

The main Jewish religious symbol is the Star of David, which symbolizes the connection between God, Israel, and the Torah, further emphasizing how the Torah united the Jewish people. Another Jewish religious symbol in the Torah is the Menorah, Hebrew for "lamp." The Menorah symbolizes the creation in seven days, with the center light representing the Sabbath. The Rabbi also had other symbols featured in the mosaic floors of churches, such as the menorah, ark of the law, shofar, incense shovel, and more. They valued symbolism as more than half of the mosaic floors in churches contain Jewish symbols.

Familial and social hierarchy were other factors that kept the Jewish community together. The Torah specifically states that it is a man's duty to extend their family tree, or he will not be able to fulfill many Jewish laws. The purpose of marriage was to increase responsibility for husband and wife and to procreate. An unmarried man cannot fulfill many Jewish laws regarding marriage and child-rearing (Wieselberg, 1992). Any Rabbi who was married was looked up to as a role model, as it was looked upon as following Judaic principles. Judaism not only talks about the importance of marriage but also addresses how it should be done. Intermarriage is considered taboo in the Jewish community, and concerns regarding this type of relationship can be found across denominations and religious observances. Jewish values are beyond just that of marriage. Education and financial status provide a very distinct hierarchy in the community with the Rabbi holding one of the most important positions in society.

From the beginning of Judaism up to the modern day, religion has fluctuated greatly in number and spread worldwide. From Abraham until the split of Israel and Judah, the Jewish population had grown to around 5 million. However, the number dropped to an all-time low of approximately 0.3 million after the Assyrian and Babylonian exiles. During this time, the Jewish diaspora to different parts of the world began (Judaism). However, in Spain, the Crusades caused

many Jews to be killed, forced to convert, or forced to migrate to escape persecution (Judaism). In 1517 CE, many Jews moved to the Ottoman Empire and built a large community there. By the mid-17th century, Jews were widely scattered across the Mediterranean, the Middle East, and Europe, with many migrating to North America in the 18th century (Judaism). From that point, the Jewish population spiked dramatically to its all-time high of 16.6 million. However, during World War II, Jews were persecuted and massacred by the German Nazis, with an estimated two-thirds of the population, or 6 million European Jews being murdered as a result of the Holocaust. Since then, the Jews have been steadily increasing in number and have a population of 14 million today. They are dispersed worldwide, but most live in the United States or Israel.

In conclusion, Judaism has survived for thousands of years because of its strong beliefs and traditions. Despite facing exile, oppression, and the destruction of their temples, the Jewish people stayed connected through their faith in the Torah and the leadership of Rabbis. These Rabbis not only guided the community spiritually but also helped keep Jewish culture alive. Core beliefs like the covenant with God, the importance of family, and symbols like the Star of David and Menorah have kept the Jewish identity strong. Through all their struggles, the Jewish people's resilience and commitment to their faith have allowed Judaism to continue thriving today.

Baha’ism

Baha’ism was created in the 19th century, and it has grown ever since. Baha’ism follows in the footsteps of Islamic religion and aims for equality for all people. It aims to connect religion with current societal norms by being adaptable. An example of its connection is how it resonates with ongoing societal issues like education and sustainability. Additionally, there is an emphasis on the coexistence of scientific knowledge and moral values, making it a flexible religion. As a result, Bahaism places more importance on solving contemporary complications rather than focusing on archaic religious practices.

Firstly, to understand what Baha’ism is, we must look at the history of the religion. Before Bahaism was created, Mirza Husayn-Ali, better known as Baha’u’llah, was a follower of the Bab. After Bab's execution and martyrdom, a small group of his followers attempted to assassinate the current ruler. The government initiated a violent movement to suppress the Bab’s followers. Baha’u’llah and most of the Bab’s followers were violently persecuted, and Baha’u’llah was thrown into prison. After his 4 months in prison, Baha’u’llah was released from prison. He traveled to what is now known as Iran, writing several books such as *The Hidden Words*, *The Seven Valleys*, *The Four Valleys*, and the *Book of Certitude*. These later became the sacred texts of Baha’ism called *Kitáb-i-Aqdas*. Baha’u’llah put equality and nature above all, striving to better the lives of his followers. When Baha’u’llah ascended, that day was considered holy, along with the birth and martyrdom of the Bab, and the birth of Baha’u’llah. After his death, Abdul-Baha took his place as the prophet of god.

To understand how Baha’ism has snowballed so quickly, we must know what distinguishes them from other religions. First, we need to look at the beliefs of Christianity, they

believe that Jesus is the son of god and their morals are to be generous, honest, and having faith. Additionally, there is an imbalance of female and male rights. Later on, Islam was formed. They have similar beliefs to Christianity, but there is the idea that there is no son of god and there is less of an imbalance between male and females. Baha'ism is different as it believes that prophets or messengers of god are neither person nor god, but between the two. While it experienced significant growth, Baha'ism still had few believers. That quickly changed as people from the region started migrating to East Asia, Europe, and North America. Currently, Baha'ism has followers all over the world and that figure is only going to keep growing.

Unlike other religions, Baha'ism believes that all major religions are from the one true god progressively revealing himself to humanity through all of the past prophets. Baha'ism also differs from other religions due to the knowledge of science in their sacred text, and having authoritative guidelines that help with the present day problems people may have, while still being flexible enough to adapt.

Baha'ism has a unique take on the afterlife. While some religions like Christianity believe that people who follow the word of god go to Heaven, Baha'ism says otherwise. They believe that once a person dies, their body turns to dust and returns to the Earth while their spirit goes to god. They compare a human being to a bird in a cage. When a person is alive, their body holds the spirit back. However, once they die, their spirit is released and becomes more powerful.

Although the Universal House of Justice is explicitly authorized to change or repeal its legislation as conditions change, thus providing Bahá'í law with an essential element of flexibility, it cannot abrogate or change any of the laws explicitly laid down in the sacred Text. (Bahá'u'lláh (The Kitáb-i-Aqdas)) This highlights their adaptability because it allows their religion to change over time, while keeping core values. They are great at adapting to current

problems that are happening worldwide. This can be seen when Baha'u'llah wrote “If religious beliefs and opinions are found contrary to the standards of science, they are mere superstitions and imaginations; for the antithesis of knowledge is ignorance, and the child of ignorance is superstition. Unquestionably, there must be agreement between true religion and science. If a question is found contrary to reason, faith and belief in it are impossible, and there is no outcome but wavering and vacillation ("The Unity").

The following quote illustrates a unique stance of Baha’ism. “Religion and Science are the two wings upon which man's intelligence can soar into the heights, with which the human soul can progress. It is not possible to fly with one wing alone! Should a man try to fly with the wing of religion alone he would quickly fall into the quagmire of superstition, whilst on the other hand, with the wing of science alone he would also make no progress, but fall into the despairing slough of materialism” ("The Unity"). This quote shows how Baha’ism aims to be flexible and unifying by combining the ideas of religion and science. Additionally, Baha’ism also promotes religious knowledge, for example the 12 principles. The 12 principles include the oneness of mankind and universal education, which corroborate the unifying nature of Baha’ism..

Baha’ism attempts to solve societal issues by using both ideas from religious beliefs and scientific knowledge. Health is a significant issue in today’s society, and Baha’ism takes a somewhat liberal approach to most situations. When it comes to basic needs such as illness and disease Baha’is take no objection to prayer as a way of healing, but they recommend seeing a physician (Rumun 1). This is how Baha’ism strays from other religions, as in Christianity there is the belief of healing from god rather than medical procedures. Furthermore, a heated issue in society right now is abortion. Baha'is also have a somewhat liberal approach to the issue, believing abortion is acceptable if there is a medical issue that leads to the death of the mother.

This proves how Baha'i beliefs allow for modern solutions to modern problems and do not rely solely on outdated scriptures. Although Baha'is are primarily liberal, they do have conservative beliefs, such as strict restrictions on the use of alcohol. Alcohol is not permitted to drink or to use when cooking. This belief is also practical due to its health benefits, as overconsumption of alcohol can lead to high blood pressure, cardiomyopathy and more (Rumun 2).

Other than health, there is another societal issue, discrimination toward groups of people. These separations can be because of the color of one's skin, sexuality, gender, and religion. Baha'ism deals with the issue of discrimination very well as it believes in the oneness of humanity and the unity of people. As stated earlier, Baha'ism believes that all religions are one and everyone who worships another religion is still Baha'i (Rumun 2). This sense of unity that Baha'ism strongly promotes supports their opposition to discrimination and prejudice, which they believe to be "one of the most pressing imperatives of all time" (Combating Racism).

In conclusion, Bahaism aims to be a progressive fusion of all major religions, combining past and present values with scientific knowledge. Additionally, its ability to put equality and moral values above other beliefs makes it stand out to followers who want a better world to live in. Furthermore, Baha'ism is a very adaptable religion because the Universal House of Justice constantly adjusts to present-day problems and provides authoritative guidelines for them. As a result, Baha'ism is able to solve the problems in medicine to discrimination of religion, Baha'ism finds solutions to many problems that older religions are unable to address.

Shintoism

Shintoism, meaning the way of the gods, originated in Japan and existed before the 6th century C.E., although the name was standardized in the 8th century (Watt). Since then, it has served as Japan's native belief system, with no indication as to who the original creator was. Through the emergence of new religions across the continent, the influence of Shintoism, as a religion, diminished. Even though many consider Shintoism to exist solely as a religion due to its worship of nature spirits known as *kami* (Hirai), Shintoism's central concepts, such as forming a harmonious relationship between humans and nature, highlight Shintoism's introspective nature and its contemporary integration into Japanese society as a lifestyle rather than a religion.

Since the beginnings of Shintoism, the reverence of nature has always been a central belief. Followers of Shintoism worshiped spirits known as the *kami*, who represented various aspects of the natural world, including earth, wind, and fire. The main *kami* was the goddess *Amaterasu Omikami* who represented the sun. It was also believed that once a person was deceased, they too would become *kami* (Kitasawa 479). Shrines were built in wooded areas, in which followers would arrive to worship and pay respects to their ancestors. It was thought that praying to the *kami* would allow the spirits to watch over them, provide protection, and live with them as if they were still alive. Both men and women were allowed to hold religious positions under Shintoism. Although there was no absolute social hierarchy, women were considered to be the conduits between spirits and men while men were tasked with implementing the will of the spirits. There was no central scripture that dictated how devotion to the *kami* should be shown because this religion developed in a pre-literate society. Although there were certain customary practices at the time, the common belief was that each follower could develop their creed and

way of worship. The central concepts were simply respect for nature and an emphasis on truthfulness, respect, and purity. Such freedom in worship is uncommon in most religions.

The manners in which followers dedicated themselves to Shinto permitted a lot of flexibility. This allowed them to live their lives based on their interpretations of Shintoism, instead of adhering to strict and formulaic practices. The lack of a standardized form of scripture allowed Shinto beliefs and practices to develop and adapt over time based on current circumstances (Hirai). This catalyzed Shintoism's transition from a religion to a philosophy. During the early periods of Shintoism, agriculture was a major part of Japanese society's way of life. Therefore, there was an increased dedication to the *kami*, in hopes that their prayers would yield good fortune in regards to natural resources. Such dedication to the *kami* parallels that of other religions to their deity(ies), cementing Shintoism as its religion at the time. However, as this dependency on agricultural practices passed, more emphasis was placed on the belief that humans were also partially divine. This allowed the attitude towards the *kami* to transition from devotion to respect.

Although the Shinto religion never spread beyond the Japanese Empire (Kitasawa 479), newer religions introduced in Japan influenced the Shinto culture and way of life. The arrival of Buddhism in the 6th century forced the integration of the two religions. While the Japanese were not yet introduced to the philosophies Buddhism presented, they were intrigued by Buddhist art, as well as forming connections with China, where Buddhism had already spread. This led to Buddhism incorporating Shinto ideologies into its religion, creating an adapted version separate from Indian Buddhism. As such, Shinto practices, such as paying respect to deceased ancestors, the respect of nature, as well as the worship towards the *kami,* have weaved their way into common Japanese belief. As Buddhism became the prominent religion in Japan for a growing

population, for these people, Shintoism turned into less of a religion, but more so a Japanese philosophy.

Shintoism reemerged as a religion during the events of World War II. Since Japan needed a unified and unique religion to uphold militaristic values during the war, Shintoism became the state religion to do such, due to it having ideologies regarding independence in worship. However, upon Japan's defeat, the Allies, led by the US, initiated the Shinto Directive which justified the separation of church and state and abolished Shintoism as the state religion (Pye). This separation caused the Emperor to disclaim his divine status as the direct descendant of the sun goddess *Amaterasu* (Rambelli). This abolishment aided Shintoism's transformation, once again, into a philosophy and lifestyle.

In the modern era, the values of Shintoism are still deeply rooted in Japanese society, regardless of religion. Seasonal festivities highlight the Shinto reverence for nature, providing offerings to the *kami*, while the Bon festival honors deceased ancestors (Toshio). Additionally, many Japanese families have shrines dedicated to their ancestors, where they provide offerings to the *kami.* Shinto shrines are commonplace around Japan, though they are not used exclusively for devotion to the *kami*. They are often used as places for community gatherings and visited before significant life events, such as births and weddings (Hirai). The Shinto values of purity, respect, and mindfulness have influenced other Japanese traditions, including theater and martial arts. Recurring motifs of natural elements in Japanese architecture imply their continued desire for harmony between man and nature. Though 70% of Japanese citizens consider themselves secular, Shinto philosophy is still highly prevalent in their way of life (Toshio).

Shintoism's transformation from a religion to a philosophy reflects its adaptability, largely due to the lack of a central scripture. The interplay between cultural, social, and historical forces

has shaped its role in current Japanese society. The integration of Shintoism and Buddhism as well as its reemergence as a state religion in World War II illustrate how external influences and global events have continually redefined its significance. However, Shintoism still has an enduring influence on Japanese culture in modern-day society. The core beliefs of Shintoism - reverence for nature, respect for ancestors, as well as values of respect and purity have had an enduring presence throughout these periods. This suggests that the true strength of Shintoism is its ability to transcend traditional religious boundaries and embed itself into a country's culture and identity. Therefore, Shintoism takes its place in current Japanese society as a philosophy that is a testament to the enduring power of culture and beliefs to adapt and thrive amidst changing circumstances.

Confucianism

In the 6th-5th century BCE, Kongzi, a Chinese scholar, preached about ethics and morality during social interactions; his teachings were later followed by hundreds of thousands across East Asia for more than 2 millennia(Adler, “Confucianism”). Although initially his ideas and beliefs were not very popular nor taken seriously, they were popularized in China after his death by two Confucian scholars, Meniscus and Xun-zi, his disciples (Mark, “Confucianism”). They preached that all humans are born equal, innately good, and deserve respect. However, throughout history, Confucian ideals have often been used to maintain governmental stability through patriarchal bureaucracies.

In modern times, many people believe that Confucianism is a religion. However, it is more a way of life and philosophy. Confucianism does not have any gods, nor is there any specific way to pray, enabling it to coexist with religions (Adler, “Confucianism”). Confucianism is based on the 4 books and 5 classics, such as *The Analects of Confucius* and *The Works of Mencius* (Mark, “Confucianism”). The most important of these two is the Analects of Confucius, a sacred text that contains all the beliefs and Confucius’s teachings. As time progressed, Confucianism spread throughout Chinese client states such as Japan, Korea, and Vietnam. An example of this is the Temple of Literature, located in Vietnam.

Confucianism is a self-centered way of life with five core beliefs for followers to structure their lives around. The first belief, “Ren,” or a sense of humanity, was considered the highest possible virtue followers could achieve (Du and Ye, Confucianism). Confucianism believed that through “Ren, ” society would flourish with the respect, love, and compassion people showed. The next belief was called “Li, ” or proper conduct, which stated that rituals or rights be done ethically (Du and Ye, Confucianism). This was followed by “Yi,” which stood for

righteousness and prosperity (Du and Ye, Confucianism). It preached justice and a heart that is in the right place. The last two beliefs were “Xin,” which stood for integrity and trustworthiness, and “Zhong,” which represented loyalty to superiors and the state. Confucianism depicted a clear structure for relationships, many of which were unequal (Du and Ye, Confucianism). This structure included a Ruler to the subject, Father to Son, Husband to Wife, Elder to Younger, and Friend to Friend. The first 4 of these were considered to be “unequal” relationships. A consequence of these ideals was a reverence of education and scholarship. For example, the civil service exam, an extremely difficult exam needed for government positions, was created during the reign of Confucianism as the official state religion in China (Adler, “Confucianism”). An important characteristic of Confucianism was the idea that one’s standing can be advanced through education in appropriate morals and ethics. In addition, Confucius also advocated for constant self reflection about your social interactions and ethics (Adler, “Confucianism”). Through these beliefs and structures, scholars believed that a prosperous and just society could be formed.

Though the tenets of Confucianism promote equality and benevolence, they can also feed a cycle of inequality by advising complacency and contentedness. Though revolts against leaders are possible, as Confucius intended, the system enabled by Confucianism can easily be used to prevent any rebellion as long as a relatively competent leader is in power. This system may have united China in specific cases but organizing revolts under it was difficult. Only when the leader became especially corrupt or incompetent were these attempts successful. Furthermore, these frequent revolts against unsatisfactory leaders, stations that were passed down through nepotism, repeatedly threw China into chaos and fractured the already unstable power distributions among the noble factions. This could have easily been avoided if a merit-based system governed the

state instead of a rigid, lineage based social hierarchy. In recent times, governments have also used Confucianism to oppress the population. For example, the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) has transformed Confucianism into a tool for unity and control (Cheng, "Negotiating the Gap: Communism and Confucianism—What the Struggle Between China's Two Competing Social Philosophies Tells Us About the Country's Future"). Although Mao Zedong initially rejected and restricted any notion of Confucianism, like the dynasties before it, the Chinese Communist Party has attempted to modify the original Confucian beliefs to reflect their ideology in more recent times (Cheng, "Negotiating the Gap: Communism and Confucianism—What the Struggle Between China's Two Competing Social Philosophies Tells Us About the Country's Future").

Another notable problem is gender inequality, as the cultural context in which Confucianism emerged was patriarchal. Women were to obey what any man ordered them to do, regardless of age or relation. Foot binding, popularized during the Song dynasty (960-1279 CE), was a cruel beauty standard held for women until 1905 in China. Girls as young as 5 were forced to fit their feet into very small shoes, which ranged from 3 to 4 inches long (National Geographic Editors, "Confucianism"). This caused them immense pain, infections that limited their ability to walk, and poor growth. This way of life was hard to maintain due to toenail growth which could rupture the skin or cause paralysis. Most women could not walk for long periods of time nor could they work. They completely depended on their male relatives and husbands to survive, furthering the inequality between wives and their husbands. Foot binding indicated if a woman was willing to obey the men around her, and limited her mobility and power, resulting in a perceived inferiority between sexes. These practices could lead to oppression within the household and in society at large.

Confucianism as a philosophy played a large part in influencing the development of China and East Asia. Many modern East Asian societal norms are based on Confucian philosophies and ideas, even though it was evident within the history of Confucianism that elements of social hierarchy and power are held in higher regard than equality and respect. The disfiguration of women's feet as a symbol of trust and submission emphasized "doing one's role in society" and conforming to societal norms. The rigid social hierarchy instated by Confucianism has been used throughout the centuries to oppress and subjugate the population of China. Though scholars like to believe that the Confucian hierarchical system supports its tenets of equality and benevolence, its legacy as a tool for unity and control continues to prevail.



Buddhism

While many spend their lives craving wealth, Buddha Gautam explained how people should live humbly yet still pursue their own desires. In Buddhism, the idea of living in between self-indulgence and selflessness is known as the Middle Way (Hardy). The primary principle of Buddhism is the value of reaching enlightenment through one's own efforts. Buddhists believe in the journey of suffering and that the Middle Way helps individuals end their own suffering, stop accumulating karma, and calmly exit the cycle of reincarnation. This ultimately guides them towards spiritual salvation and the understanding of greater purposes beyond the material world, fostering peaceful acceptance of life’s impermanence.

Siddhartha Gautama, or Buddha Gautam, founded Buddhism to end people’s suffering and to promote the Middle Way. The Middle Way is the balance between self-indulgence and selflessness. It is also a part of the process to reach enlightenment, when buddhists stop being reincarnated because they gained a sufficient amount of wisdom and followed certain practices and principles in Buddhist culture (Hardy). When Siddhartha left his luxurious castle to face the outside world for the first time, he was disturbed to see the suffering of a senile man, an ill person, and a corpse being carried to cremation (Singer). However, Siddhartha also encountered a monk meditating, which compelled him to lead an ascetic, religious life that could alleviate suffering for others. He devotedly prayed under a fig tree (known as the Bodhi tree in religious research) and eventually attained enlightenment. Siddhartha's enlightenment helped him gain mindfulness and teach others about it.

Buddhists believe in enlightenment and its effect on karma, dharma, reincarnation, and one’s view of life (Mark). Buddhists believe that after enlightenment, people feel a sense of

closure as they have gained wisdom, and then gracefully pass on to not be reincarnated again. In modern society, reincarnation is often disregarded, as people grieve over loved ones nearing death, feeling distressed that their loved ones may never return. The Buddhist religion gives its people some sense of hope and peace at the loss of loved ones, knowing that, in religious settings, they will not be taken away until they are at peace and are knowledgeable enough to pass.

While the philosophical concept of enlightenment in Buddhism may contrast with how people think of dying individuals today, the "three poisons" and sins as per Buddhism's moral ethics strongly support a framework for a benevolent society. The three poisons are greed, aggression, and ignorance: greed fuels monetary crime, aggression contributes to violent acts, and ignorance can cause prejudice and hate against overlooked groups (Wayman 107). The three poisons can contribute to a number of malevolent actions that can contribute not only the suffering of oneself, but the suffering of all those in the vicinity of the action. The difference between Buddhism and modern-day society is the possibility of redemption and punishment; nowadays, we send criminals to restrictive punishments like prison. However, Buddhism promotes advancing past mistakes with newfound wisdom while granting freedom to pursue enlightenment. The circumstances of the individual's situation is taken into account when leading them to the path of enlightenment, reflecting the principles of compassion and understanding in Buddhism (Mark).

In Buddhism, there are many important symbols, texts, and places that revolve around the journey to enlightenment. One of the most important Buddhist texts, the Tipitaka, also known as the "three baskets," are a collection of the earliest Buddhist writings. Unlike other religious texts, such as the Christian Bible or Islamic Qur-an, the Tipitaka wasn't based on the words of a god,

but is focused more on the teachings of Buddha (Williams 156). Buddha propounded the values in Sutras, which are the sacred teachings of Buddhism that aim to educate people in the essential morals of the religion. Of these sutras, the Lotus Sutra is seen as the most significant sutra of Buddhism (Namgyal 29); it describes Buddha's enlightenment and believes that everyone has the ability to become enlightened. The Sutra also guides individuals to gain enlightenment through the Middle Way (SGI USA).

Although the principles in the Sutras were known for maintaining peace and avoiding conflict, Buddhist warrior monks, known as Shaolins and Soheis, have used arguments similar to those who supported the Crusades (a series of holy wars aiming to forcefully spread Christianity to other parts of the world) (Keown). The violent judgment of religious leaders, although against the ethical teachings of Buddha, was often rationalized and did not bring upon them consequences of karma. Most notably, during the Kamakura period in Japan, the teachings of Zen Buddhism were intertwined with samurai war training. The blend of martial and spiritual practices created tension within Buddhism, as Buddhist principles that conventionally advocated for peace were repurposed to justify the violent actions of samurai (Keown).

There are 488 million Buddhists globally (Hackett et al. 31). Buddhism is divided into three main branches; Mahayana, Vajrayana, and Theravada. Mahayana Buddhism is assumed to be the largest branch with the most followers in countries such as China, Japan, South Korea, and Vietnam. Theravada is the second largest branch; its followers mainly live in Thailand, Burma, Sri Lanka, Laos, and Cambodia. Vajrayana Buddhism is the smallest branch, with followers mainly living in Tibet, Nepal, Bhutan, and Mongolia.

Buddhism originated from India; however, its beliefs spread around Asia as a result of silk, a Chinese good, being the primary commodity traded in the market (Neelis). Particularly,

98.7% of Buddhist followers live in Asia-Pacific countries, 3.9 million followers live in North America, and 1.3 million live in Europe (Hackett et al. 39). However, the top 10 countries with the most Buddhist followers are all in the Asia-Pacific area with the highest number being 50% of Buddhists living in China (Hackett et al. 32).

In Buddhism, men and women are seen as equals and are expected to respect and be faithful towards each other. The parents have the responsibility to teach Buddhist practices to their children, while the children should obey and preserve the Buddhist culture (Schobert and Taylor). Many religions and cultures like Muslims, Hinduism, and Sikhs believe in caste systems that categorize people based on their status. However, Buddhism does not believe in caste systems and sees everyone as individuals with equal standing (Sahgal et al. 96).

Additionally, Buddhists believe that there is no heaven, hell, or afterlife. Followers of Buddhism believe you become reincarnated after death and that it is a continuous process that happens over and over again until enlightenment. Karma plays a big role in reincarnation as people's past actions determine how future life may be. However, different types of Buddhists have slightly different views on reincarnation. For example, Theravada Buddhism believes that the continuity of consciousness and karma are the most important part of reincarnation (Hardy).

Buddhism emphasizes the importance of focusing on the Middle Way, gaining insight, and collecting good karma as its essential philosophies. These principles are designed to help individuals achieve enlightenment, navigate daily challenges, and live a balanced life. Adhering to the requirements for good karma and following the Middle Way is believed to foster spiritual knowledge and profoundly enhance one’s understanding of life’s purpose.

Hinduism

Hinduism, the world's oldest religion, is practiced worldwide and includes a variety of philosophies and practices. It is a polytheistic religion and also serves as the foundation for other religions such as Buddhism and Jainism. The founder is usually considered as Brahma, the creator of the Universe in Hindu mythology, but there is no clear evidence as to who founded Hinduism. Even though Hinduism is often described as being a "family of religions", it is more accurately a family of traditions unified by common practices and features, such as shared rituals, festivals, belief in reincarnation, the pursuit of liberation, and the Caste System.

There are hundreds of festivals celebrated in Hinduism, all with a purpose and history. A few are Diwali, Dussehra, and Mahashivratri. Diwali is the festival of light. It is celebrated differently in the North and South of India. In the North, it is celebrated to honor Rama, an avatar of Vishnu, returning home from exile. In the South, it is celebrated to honor Lord Krishna defeating Naraka, a demon who was misusing his powers. A lot of devotees who want to follow the path of service celebrate this festival because it celebrates the defeat of evil using physical prowess. Another festival is Mahashivaratri, also called "The Great Night of Shiva", as this is the day that Shiva, the god of destruction, marries his wife Parvati, and performs his divine dance, the Tandava (Sadhguru). This festival appeals more to those of the Upanishadic path, as it is more of a spiritual festival. These festivals give people of all castes and wealth different ways to achieve Moksha. Even though some festivals are spiritualistic and some are more physical, many are celebrated by all Hindus, connecting the entire population of Hinduism.

In addition, common rituals connect various aspects of Hindu life, as well as assist in achieving moksha. Puja, honoring the deity, is a main tradition that serves as a unifying function

in Hinduism (Tavares 70). A puja is a worship ritual performed to offer devotion to a deity. The giving of food (prasada) is actually meant to be a response to the generosity that gave all Hindus life. Eating prasada means accepting their status as inferior and dependent on the deities (Tavares 79). A puja highlights the process of sacrifices and offerings which are used in many religious activities spread throughout all of Hinduism. There are 4 rites of passages (samskaras) in Hinduism: Jatakarma, Upanayana, Vivaha, and Antyeshti. Jatakarma, the first rite of passage, encompasses the birth ceremonies performed to protect the fetus from harm (Tavares 72). Upanayana, the second rite of passage, is the Ceremony of the Sacred Thread, which symbolizes the initiation of an individual into the Hindu community. During the ceremony, a sacred thread is given, symbolizing connection to the spiritual world. The third rite of passage is Vivaha, or marriage. Most hindu marriages are arranged by the parents, and partners are usually of the same caste (Tavares 73). Lastly, the fourth rite of passage is Antyeshti, which is the cremation and rites of the dead (Tavares 74). Historically, Hindus have cremated the dead and wish for their ashes to be placed in the River Ganga, believing that its holy water will purify the soul and ease the transition into their next life. Rituals like puja or samskaras come from the Hindu belief of samsara (continuous cycle of life).

Hindus believe in reincarnation after death. This process of reincarnation will repeat itself until the person obtains Moksha, which is the goal for Hinduism. Karma is the sum of one's actions in life, and can be considered as a point system. If one fulfills their dharma, their duty to family and society, they will gain good karma. Your karma determines how you will be reincarnated. Good karma allows one to be reincarnated in a higher caste. Living multiple lives with increasing karma is a way that Hindus use to achieve Moksha.

Moksha is regarded as the highest of the four ultimate goals for a Hindu, the others being duty, enjoyment, and wealth (Young 11). It is the liberation from the reincarnation cycle and is earned from the buildup of good karma throughout the lifetimes. According to *Yoga: Paths to Moksha*, there are four pathways to achieve Moksha. These four pathways are Bhakti, Jhana, Karma, and Raja.

Bhakti is the pathway of devotion and is when a person seeks God out of deep love and respect for him ("Yoga: Paths to Moksha" 1). Through Bhakti, people can connect personally with God in various ways such as a father or friend. Jhana is the pathway of knowledge and relates to self realization and intellect. People who choose this path have to complete three steps to achieve moksha ("Yoga: Paths to Moksha" 2). This pathway as a whole is to help people realize who they are, what their purpose is, and connect with god. The third pathway is Karma, which is the path of selfless action. In this path, a person should work hard without expecting anything in return, because they believe they are doing God's work ("Yoga: Paths to Moksha" 3). The final pathway is Raja, the path of discipline. This path is also known as Ashtanga because there are eight spiritual components in this path ("Yoga: Paths to Moksha" 4). Hindus believe yoga makes up this spiritual path by clearing the conscience, stabilizing the body, and controlling the breath. Although it's known as a difficult path, one can still obtain Moksha with enough practice.

Even though there are four distinct pathways to achieving Moksha, the harsh social stratification of Hinduism can make this journey harder for many. While anyone can achieve Moksha, The Caste System often limits spiritual opportunities to attain Moksha, especially for people in the lower castes. The caste system first appeared upon the arrival of the Aryans in 1500 BCE who took over northern India. Over time, the caste system has developed alongside and

became intertwined with Hinduism, dividing Hindus into different groups that determine who they can marry, what they can do, and even what they can wear. This complex social system divides people into 4 varnas: Brahmins, Kshatriya, Vaishya & Sudra. At the top of the hierarchy, Brahmins are known as the traditional priest class who also serve as teachers and advisers to kings. Below them, Kshatriya are known as the warrior class, whose main job was to protect Brahmans. Third, the Vaishya are mostly merchants and farmers and fourth, the Sudra are local workers and farmers who provide for the higher castes. Below the four classes are the "untouchables", who aren't even a part of the caste system and are considered unclean since birth. The "untouchables" are in charge of "polluted" jobs such as working with dead animals or cleaning sewage. If someone is born into an "untouchable" family, it is impossible to change caste as you're not allowed access to education or a good job, nor can you be married into another caste (Hackney). This social system is crucial to Hinduism as it reinforces the belief that you are born into the caste you deserve and that your previous life's karma determines what caste you are born into. It's also crucial because it is accepted by all Hindus and is used in many aspects of Hinduism.

Despite its ambiguity as a "religion", Hinduism is a collection of common traditions and practices that all unite a population. Hinduism's hundreds of festivals celebrate the facets of the religion, while the caste system continues to influence society in India. Hinduism's belief in reincarnation shapes their understanding of life and pursuit of liberation. The multiple paths that devotees can take all lead to a divine singularity, moksha. These common core practices connect the structure of Hinduism, emphasizing a family amid religious diversity.

Aztec Belief System

The Aztecs were a powerful empire that flourished in the Valley of Mexico during the 14th to 16th century AD. Tenochtitlan, their sprawling capital city, was located roughly in the center of Mesoamerica. When Spanish conquistadors arrived in Tenochtitlan in 1521 AD, they were fascinated by the city's extreme artistic expression and clean organization. However, they were also horrified to witness their captured men being sacrificed to the gods by the Aztec soldiers. This painted a contrast within the great Aztec civilization - one that embraced logic, advancement, and artistic refinement and one defined by warfare, sacrifice, and profound devotion to the gods (Carrasco, "Aztec Religion"). Although the Aztec religion was known for its human sacrifices, they justified their practices of extreme devotion, sacrifices, and warfare as a way to nourish and sustain the deities in order to maintain the stability of their civilization and the universe.

Around 1325 AD, a group of early nomadic Aztecs, known as the Chicimecs, wandered into the Valley of Mexico, an area filled with warring territories, where they interacted with various city-states and their religious traditions. Eventually, the early Aztecs settled in Tenochtitlan, which would eventually become the center of their powerful empire. The Aztec belief system was syncretic; the religion was a combination of ritual, mystic, and cosmic elements that they absorbed from various cultural groups in the area and transformed themselves. They also drew inspiration from the early imperial city of Teotihuacan, 30 miles north of where Tenochtitlan would rise a thousand years later. The Aztecs saw Teotihuacan as a symbolic place of origin and a source of legitimacy for their political power. They came to believe that Teotihuacán was the birthplace of their gods, and they were descendants of the Toltecs, who were the "chosen" people of the gods (Benson, et al.).

The Aztecs believed in and worshiped hundreds of gods, including Ometeotl, the primordial God and creator of the universe, who had both a female and male part that bore four sons: Huitzilopochtli, God of sun and war, Tonatiuh, God of the sun, Tlaloc, God of rain, and Quetzalcoatl, God of light ("Aztec Religion"). Huitzilopochtli, the chief God of war and the sun, was believed to have led the Aztecs in the form of a hummingbird. They believed that he was reborn every morning and made his way across the heavens, nourished only by the beating hearts of sacrificed warriors. His cult became central to Aztec society, and as it grew, there was a significant increase in human sacrifices (Benson, et al.). Quetzalcoatl, known as the feathered serpent, was a well-respected god associated with light, knowledge, and vegetation. He is seen as the God who created humanity and the Earth itself. Quetzalcoatl's rivalry with Tezcatlipoca, another prominent deity, led to a mythological battle that symbolized the balance between life and death. In mythology, their reconciliation represents the duality in many Aztec beliefs, such as light and darkness (Benson, et al.). In Aztec mythology, many gods, including Quetzalcoatl, are said to have self-sacrificed to create the new cosmic age and save humanity from destruction (Carrasco, "Aztec Religion"). Thus, human sacrifice was seen as necessary to reciprocate the divine sacrifices, sustain the forces of the gods, and maintain the cosmic balance of opposing forces.

Because it was considered a religious duty, warfare was essential to Aztec society. Katz explains the Aztecs' views on warfare with a quote from an Aztec chieftain, "'Are not war and victory…the true profession of the Mexicans, and is it not worth more to win victory, even through a thousand perils, than to sit at home and work like a woman?'" (17). This desire for warfare led to the conquering and habitation of a great amount of land, which contributed to the spread of the Aztec religion. Even though fighting and waging wars were part of religious duty

for the Aztecs, there might have been a deeper, underlying connection between their lust for battle and their beliefs. Warriors were often selected for sacrificial purposes, so battle allowed them to acquire prisoners (Carrasco, "Aztec"). When the supply of sacrifice victims started to dwindle, the Aztecs would engage in military exercises called Flower Wars. These were scheduled between cities to simulate combat to obtain captives. This practice benefited all parties involved, as warriors got to die honorably, either in battle or by being sacrificed, and the cities were able to please the gods (Burhenn, 2).

The Aztecs believed conducting religious rituals, including human sacrifices, would nourish and repay the gods. Rituals were an essential part of Aztec religion and culture. Sacrificial ceremonies often occurred according to their religious calendar; however, they would also be practiced in times of distress, such as during a famine, to please the gods and ask for mercy (Carrasco, "Aztec Religion"). This is rooted in mythological stories of Huitzilopochtli and other important deities, who were sustained on the blood and hearts of human sacrifice - the Aztecs often raised children intending to offer them to the deities, as being sacrificed was a great honor. The sacrificed people were thought to have their section in Miktlan, the Aztec underworld ("Aztec Religion"). Despite this, human sacrifices still caused lots of suffering; sacrifices were not limited to warriors but also enslaved people, women, and children. A sacrifice would be laid out over a stone block at the top of an Aztec temple, four priests holding them down and another highly-trained priest cutting open the heart with an obsidian knife.

Due to their conquests, the Aztecs amassed a significant amount of land and resources, which the Spaniards sought. The Aztecs and the Spaniards were at war from 1519 to 1521; the Aztecs tried to preserve their traditions and way of life, while the Spaniards coveted land for the crown and gold for their empire. Although the Aztecs fought hard to protect their cities, they

were overwhelmed by the progressive weaponry and superior numbers of the Spanish. Hernan Cortes finally defeated them after his army besieged Tenochtitlán for 93 days (Carrasco, "Aztec Religion"). The Aztec empire declined after the Spanish takeover of the Aztec empire, and most Aztecs converted to Catholicism. This contributed to the erosion of traditional Aztec beliefs in modern-day society.

There were three main theories of why the Aztecs converted to Catholicism. The first theory is that the Aztecs thought the Spanish conquerors were their gods returning to claim their land. The second theory is that the Aztecs were forced to convert by the Spaniards, whose mission was to spread Catholicism. Lastly, there is a theory that Spanish missionaries combined the native religion with Christianity to facilitate conversion. Even with these viable theories combined, there is still no exact explanation of how hundreds of thousands of Aztecs converted to Catholicism. Although the belief system has died down, the Aztec rituals and language still exist. The very few remaining Aztecs and their descendants are spread out in vast areas of current-day Mexico. However, those who still practice observe a more Christian-based belief and utilize non-brutal methods (Dovas, 66).

In conclusion, the Aztecs believed they were in debt to the gods because of numerous stories of their divine self-sacrifice, fostering a deep devotion they sought to repay through their sacrifices. Human sacrifice, aimed at nourishing the gods and stabilizing the universe, was an essential part of their religion. The relentless pursuit of sacrificial victims, supplied mainly by their prisoners of war, propelled them to engage in frequent warfare. The Aztecs carried out these practices as they felt it was necessary to hold their civilization together and maintain their religious worldview.

Sikhism

More than 30 million individuals still believe in Sikhism, a religion founded in the late 15th century by Guru Nanak. The word “Sikh” means disciple in Punjabi, reflecting the followers’ devotion to the teachings of the Ten Sikh Gurus. Sikhism’s ultimate purpose is to unite with God through the human soul, as the Sikhs believe suffering occurs because of humanity’s separation from God. Most of its beliefs and ideals formed from an intersection between Hinduism and Islam. While Hinduism and Islam were principal in developing the syncretic religion Sikhism, its distinction can be found in its emphasis on caste equality and monotheistic views contrary to Hinduism and further pushing the movement for gender equality.

Guru Nanak was born into a Hindu family in Punjab, India. He received an education in Hindu lore from a village teacher and attended a Muslim school, gaining knowledge about both religions. During a time of conflict between Hindu and Muslim communities, Nanak despised the fighting, recognizing that both religions had similar ideologies and beliefs. Nanak often prayed at the river; however, one day he went missing with only his clothes seen near the riverbank. After three days, he emerged with a new revelation: “There is neither Hindu nor Muslim, so whose path shall I follow? I shall follow God’s path. God is neither Hindu nor Muslim and the path which I follow is God” (Lewis, “Sikhism”).

Sikhism originated in the Punjab region of India through the teachings of the Ten Sikh Gurus, starting with Guru Nanak and ending with Guru Gobind Singh. The religion quickly grew in the Punjab region as Guru Nanak preached and prayed in Punjabi, allowing him to “reach ordinary Punjabis” (Singh, “The Rise of Sikh Belief and Community”). As Guru Nanak preached, the religion gained traction not only in India but also in parts of Pakistan. Simultaneously, the Mughal Empire was established. The fifth guru, Guru Arjan, put together

what would become the Sikh holy book, the Adi Granth (later called the Guru Granth Sahib), which compiled teachings from the previous Sikh Gurus, Hindu Bhaktas, and Muslim Sufi saints. The fifth guru also raised tensions for the first time in Sikh history when he gave refuge to a Mughal political rebel. The conflict against the Mughals continued after the ninth guru, Guru Tegh Bahadur, sheltered a group of Hindu Brahmins (Lewis, “Sikhism and Sant Mat”).

However, it was not until the 10th guru Gobind Singh created the Khalsa, a militant and political power of baptized Sikhs, that the Sikhs would find success in their battle against the Mughals. Originally, the Khalsa was created as a religious brotherhood that showed true dedication to the Sikh lifestyle. Members got baptized by amrit, or holy water, and were expected to uphold the 5 K’s: kesh, uncut hair; kangh, a comb; kach, pants that don’t go past the knees; kara, a steel bracelet or bangle; and kirpan, a short sword (Lewis, “Sikhism”). What was most unique about this community was that it was open to men and women of all castes; this gesture showed how they made Sikhism a religion of inclusion rather than discrimination. More specifically on gender equality, Sikhism believes in an egalitarian society. Guru Nanak stressed that "a woman is one-half of the complete personality of a man,” suggesting that men and women are equal (Kaur 2). This is in contrast to Islamic views, where two women are seen as equal to one man (Iqbal, “Are two female witnesses equal to one in Islam?”). As wars between the Mughal Empire and the Sikhs continued, the Khalsa transitioned into a military force (Lewis, “Sikhism and Sant Mat”).

In 1799, the Sikhs captured the city of Lahore, in Pakistan, and established it as their capital. Similar to Hinduism and Islam, Sikhism is not a missionary religion and does not seek to force or convert others. Accordingly, despite it being an empire of Sikhs, it granted religious freedom to Hindus and Muslims. This kingdom lasted until the mid-19th century, when the Sikhs

and Great Britain went to war, with the latter emerging victorious and annexing the Sikh kingdom. A century later, in 1947, the British vacated India and split Punjab between India and Pakistan. The split was met with some criticism as many culturally important Sikh sites had been given to Pakistan, and 2.5 million Sikhs were forced to migrate to Eastern Punjab in India. Today, most Sikhs still reside in the Punjab region of India (Lewis, “Sikhism and Sant Mat”).

Despite the split, a few important religious icons and holy places that Sikhs value remain in India. The Adi Granth is an important religious symbol in Sikhism because it consists of over 5000 hymns written by the Ten Sikh Gurus. Believers sing the hymns during worship services and adhere to the teachings of the Adi Granth, which they regard as crucial. The Golden Temple, an important place of worship for Sikh believers, holds this sacred book. The temple, located in Punjab, India, is surrounded by man-made lakes including Amrit Sarovar and other museums and shrines dedicated to Sikh leaders (Gordon Melton, “Golden Temple”). Even though Afghan invaders destroyed the Golden Temple multiple times in the 18th century, it continues to stand as a testament to the resilience and devotion of Sikh believers.

In Hinduism, the four main caste groups—Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas, and Shudras—define a person’s social status. The Manusmriti, a key text in Hindu scriptures, outlines the caste system and its major role in Hindu society. It explains how generational status is inherited, determining each individual's professions and marital options. Sikhism contradicts these principles by abhorring a social hierarchy. In a day and age when people viewed rejecting the caste system as abnormal and irregular, Sikhism emerged as a unique faith. A typical gurdwara, which is a sacred place of worship and community in Sikhism, contains four doors—The Door of Peace, The Door of Livelihood, The Door of Learning, and The Door of

Grace—which symbolize the inclusivity of all people, regardless of caste. Additionally, gurdwaras have public kitchens, where people of all castes and genders can have a free meal.

Sikhism takes the Hindu idea of reincarnation and implements its monotheistic values on it. Hinduism created the idea that karma is what "determines one's destiny in a future life" ("Karma"). Performing good deeds and showing selflessness would contribute to one's good karma, while being selfish would contribute to their bad karma. Hinduism believes that the cycle of rebirth can be ended through various ways, such as following dharma—beliefs and behaviors "that are in accord with the principle of order in the universe" (Baumann, "Introduction to Hinduism")—devotion to God, or gaining spiritual knowledge. These are done to reach moksha, a realization of the soul's unity with God and the end of the cycle of samsara, or suffering. This is where Sikhism branches off in its views: Guru Nanak preached "meditating on the divine name" (Lewis, "Introduction to Sikhism") as the primary method of liberation. Sikhs simply view following dharma and devotion to God as integral in daily life. Unlike Hinduism, Sikhism is a monotheistic religion that holds devotion towards a single, formless God known as Waheguru. They believe the cycle of samsara comes from a person's soul being separated from God. So, "achieving union with the eternal one" (Lewis, "Introduction to Sikhism") was determined to be the same as ridding oneself of impurities found in the physical world.

While it incorporates elements of both Hinduism and Islam, Sikhism uses its monotheistic ideals to uniquely address issues of caste inequality and gender imbalance. Despite the decline of its empire, the religion has attracted over 30 million followers globally, and its impact continues to grow.

Daoism

Daoism was first created in 500 CE in ancient China and has influenced and shaped Chinese life for over 2,000 years (Seidel). It is often considered religious and philosophical because it contains philosophical themes while its following is more aligned with the religious aspects. While most religions' essential components focus on celestial beings, dogmas, and social stratification, Daoism is unique because its essential components, such as the key texts *Daodejing* and *Zhuangzi*, conflict with Confucianism, and the symbol yin and yang instead revolve around Daoism's core values of simplicity, harmony, and spontaneity. Because these values are extremely philosophical, Daoism should be defined as a philosophy rather than a religion which would enable it to have a wider influence.

Two important figures in the origins of Daoism were Laozi and Zhuang Zhou. Laozi, or Lao Tzu, is traditionally accredited as the founder of Daoism. Laozi lived in the Chu region of China during the Zhou dynasty (Freiberg). The classic work *Records of the Grand Historian*, which details much of Ancient China's history, describes Laozi as a philosopher rather than a prophet or relative of the divine, setting him apart from other religious founders (Mark). He was also Confucius's teacher and served as a keeper of archival records at the court of Zhou. Laozi attempted to convince people to live life in harmony with each other and the universe. He authored the main book of Daoism, the *Daodejing* (also called *Tao Te Ching*), to promote these beliefs. Another important figure in the origins of Daoism was Zhuang Zhou, a philosopher who lived during the Warring States period (Coutinho). Zhuang Zhou is known for writing the second main book of Daoism, *The Zhuangzi* (also called *Zhuang Tzu*).

Daoism was founded on several core beliefs that all center around a single question: how should one live life? Daoists believe the answer is the abstract concept of Dao, commonly

translated as “The Way”. The first lines of the *Daodejing* state that one cannot understand Dao until one has experienced Dao: “The Dao that can be trodden is not the enduring and unchanging Dao. The name that can be named is not the enduring and unchanging name” (Legge, Zi 1). Aligning oneself with the Dao brings harmony and enriches one’s life; opposition brings frustration and unhappiness. The *Daodejing* lists the three fundamental virtues—the Three Treasures—as compassion, moderation, and humility (Legge, Zi 67).

The *Daodejing* instructs the reader how to become a sage (sheng ren) and underlines one major point: the most effective action is a kind of nonaction. Those who obtain Dao will be enabled to wu-wei, or effortless action:

> “[H]e who devotes himself to the Dao (seeks) from day to day to diminish (his doing). He diminishes it and again diminishes it, till he arrives at doing nothing (on purpose). Having arrived at this point of non-action, there is nothing which he does not do” (Legge, Zi 48).

The philosophy of wu-wei is often compared to water: pick up only what is useful and discard what is too heavy to be carried.

Meanwhile, the *Zhuangzi* is a compilation of anecdotes. It emphasizes the importance of returning to a life of simplicity and becoming the perfected person (Freiberg), one who aligns with the Dao, lives spontaneously, embraces transformation, and is at peace with the world. The perfected person is not divine, but an ordinary human, such as the swimmer who does not tire because he follows the way of the water (Legge, Zi 19).

These two texts explain the core beliefs of Daoism and are both deeply philosophical. Instead of imposing ideas on the reader, they make the reader think about and question life. This contrasts with other religions’ main texts which are centered around the divine, for example, the

Bible of Christianity. Even the Qur'an is a collection of a divine being's suggestions on the way of life.

The Daoist texts also show how Daoism differs from Confucianism. Daoist texts criticize many aspects of Confucianism, especially the strict adherence to social customs. For example, the *Zhuangzi* attacks Confucius by describing fictional conversations between him and Laozi (Freiberg 181). Each conversation ends with Laozi proving Confucius wrong, and Confucious admits, "As far as the Way is concerned, I was a mere gnat in the vinegar jar! If the Master hadn't taken off the lid for me, I would never have understood the Great Integrity of Heaven and Earth!" (Freiberg). By showing the founder of Confucianism conceding to Daoism, the text intends to show Confucianists that their values are wrong. When compared to conflicts between other religions, such as arguments between Islamic and Christian beliefs about the association of Jesus with God, the Daoist conflict with Confucianism reflects more of a philosophical and moral conflict rather than a religious conflict by providing reasoning of superior values instead of disputing about deities or dogmas.

Additionally, Daoism mocks Confucianist respect for social hierarchy. "They advocated refusal to participate in the affairs of state, which they saw as manipulative and exploitive" (Freiberg 187). This is shown in the *Daodejing*, which states:

> "The people suffer from famine because of the multitude of taxes consumed by their superiors. [...]
>
> The people are difficult to govern because of the (excessive) agency of their superiors (in governing them)" (Legge, Zi 75).

Because the goal of Daoism is for everyone to coexist peacefully, appointing some people as more important than others would resist the natural way of the universe.

Philosophical values also molded one of the key symbols of Daoism: yin and yang. Yin and yang are depicted as dark and light halves of a circle, representing opposite forces such as femininity and masculinity, and evil and good. In comparison, the cross from Christianity, another major religious symbol, symbolizes the death and resurrection of Jesus, showing a focus on deities and faith. The yin-yang does not symbolize a god or a certain faith; instead, it is a representation of a philosophical belief of how the universe works.

The symbol also portrays the connection between life and death. As one approaches the fullness of yang, yin begins to horizon, and vice versa. Daoists perceive life and death as a transformation from entering nature to returning to nature (Exploring Perspective of Death According to Taoism). Their perspective of life and death as an inseparable unity links back to their essential value of harmony and how everything is balanced.

To this day, Daoism has followers in China and Taiwan and continues to leave an impact on the world with its beliefs, rich history, and principles. Yet despite its influence, Daoism has not been classified as a religion or philosophy. However, because Daoism components revolve so heavily around philosophical values of simplicity, harmony, and spontaneity, it is more justifiable to distinguish Daoism as a philosophy. Labeling Daoism as a philosophy would allow it to reach a larger audience because people who already follow a different religion would be more open to practicing Daoist beliefs.

Zoroastrianism

Founded as early as 4000 years ago, Zoroastrianism is one of the oldest religions still in existence today. Although its numbers have dwindled to just over 100,000 followers, it has played a prominent role in shaping belief systems worldwide. Despite this comparatively small following, Zoroastrianism's widespread influence and intricate history have captivated the attention of historians and theologians alike. While on the surface, Zoroastrianism revolves around the collective, primordial battle between Good and Evil, the religion evolved to primarily focus on the individual's role in leading a life of virtue through "good thoughts, good words, [and] good actions." Over time, the reason for believers to do good shifted as they stopped viewing Angra Mainyu as a physical embodiment of evil but instead as an internal combatant that people had to defeat in their minds to avoid a fate in hell.

As one of the earliest monotheistic religions and the only monotheistic religion of Indo-European origin, Zoroastrianism went against the standard polytheistic beliefs of its time. This unique perspective was introduced by the Persian prophet Zoroaster in the 6th century BC when, according to scripture, an angel guided him to Ahura Mazda, the highest God of the pantheon. The prophet declared that the eternal God had chosen him to preach against polytheism by showing him what to make of the new religion through visions. Zoroaster spread the religion by serving as a priest and working in the court of King Vishtaspa of Chorasmia, where he converted many important officials and disseminated the word of God across the Middle East.

One of Zoroastrianism's core beliefs is that the world is a battleground for good against evil. Ahura Mazda is the creator of all physical and moral elements, directing all beneficent deeds and energies as an eternal God who is wise and just. He represents good in the constant

battle against Angra Mainyu, a destructive energy embodying evil. Zoroastrianism emphasizes that humans need to uphold strong virtues throughout their lifetimes to assist Ahura Mazda in the rise to victory. As God cannot control the actions of each individual and the duel between good and evil can not be physically seen, it is up to the individual to choose Asha, the Threefold Path of Truth, Righteousness, and Order. The lack of divine intervention and physical cues creates a fundamental faith aspect where followers must believe that their good actions are necessary in the greater battle.

The Faravahar serves as a cardinal symbol that further promotes the belief that humans must choose good. The loops on each side of the Faravahar represent the opposing forces in the universe, while the human face still turns to the direction of the good. The different components of the symbol visually represent different aspects of life. For instance, the three main feathers of each wing represent good thoughts, good words, and good actions, in addition to their more obvious purpose for flight and upward progress. Clearly, symbolism was used to encourage Asha among followers as well as contrast physical and mental aspects of the battle against evil.

For centuries, Zoroastrians faced hardships and backlash as a result of their beliefs. In 480 BC, during Alexander the Great's conquest of Persia, the city of Persepolis was burned down, disrupting the progress of Zoroastrianism (Melton). Then, with the rise of Islam in the Middle East, many Islamic laws were implemented that discriminated against Zoroastrians. For example, one law required inheritors to convert to Islam in order to receive their entire family's wealth. Zoroastrians were subjected to extreme harassment by Muslims and, in some cases, underwent forced conversions. This injustice continued for centuries; in 1979, during the Islamic Revolution, the spiritual leader Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini referred to them as "reactionary worshippers" using the derogatory term "gabr" (Foltz, 77). This prolonged oppression had a

significant impact on Zoroastrian beliefs. Although Zoroaster initially introduced Angra Mainyu as a physical, tangible embodiment of evil (similar to a devil), believers eventually recognized that Angra Mainyu's true manifestation was at the inner level through lies, falsehood, and distortion, tempting people towards a path of apostasy. This epiphany led Zoroastrians to turn inwards, seeking objective morality in a fight for their fate as individuals.

The fear of death and hell became a central part of Zoroastrianism as followers dedicated their whole lives to moral righteousness, awaiting an ultimate judgment. "After death, the soul passes a bridge where it will be met by a daenā (a conscience) who will become identified with the soul. The good souls will see a good and beautiful woman, while evil ones will see a witch. It is unsure whether Chinvat, Ahura Mazda, or Mithra will be the one to judge the soul." (Oxford Reference). As strongly as Zoroastrians feared hell, it wasn't a permanent punishment like many other religions. A person's good and evil deeds could be objectively quantified, and if one's bad deeds outweighed the good, their soul would go to hell to be purified before eventually reaching heaven. "When evil is defeated, the souls of sinners will be released from hell and will be purified with molten metal. Then, they will join a congregation of gods and saints." (Avesta). This concept demonstrates the tensions between morality and physical evil, with ideas of purging evil and purification used to establish an objective morality, either in life or after death.

Hard work and recognition are among the most valued characteristics that Zoroastrians strive to exhibit. They believe that one of the greatest achievements in life is to become a *Niknam,* a person whose name will be remembered in their work even after death. This desire for an enduring legacy reflects how Zoroastrians hope to leave a profound impact on the world and follow their accomplishments (Crary, 43). Additionally, they believe that people are supposed to suffer in life, as true fulfillment and satisfaction only come in the afterlife. Consequently,

Zoroastrians regarded traits like laziness and procrastination with heavy disdain, viewing them as obstacles to spiritual growth. This perspective shows their willingness to suffer to live better in the afterlife. Laziness is a personal struggle that each individual must learn to overcome and improve upon, further demonstrating that there is some natural "evil" within everyone that is up to them to overcome.

Zoroastrianism's evolution over time has made the religion one of the most multidimensional and historically rich belief systems in history. Despite facing centuries of physical and internal struggles, Zoroastrians have persevered and adapted their beliefs to uphold their core values of truth, righteousness, and order. Its believers' shift from viewing Angra Mainyu as a physical evil to a mental one was a significant turning point, allowing the religion to survive and become what it is today.